

Ignored factors key in rise of autism

RFK Jr. says he wants to study the causes, but experts say he's shunning the science.

By CORINNE PURTILL

This week, the Trump administration announced that it was taking “bold action” to address the “epidemic” of autism spectrum disorder — starting with a new safety label on Tylenol and other acetaminophen products that suggests a link to autism. The scientific evidence for doing so is weak, researchers said.

Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. said federal officials “will be uncompromising and relentless in our search for answers” and that they soon would be “closely examining” the role of vaccines, whose alleged link to autism has been widely discredited.

Kennedy has long argued that rising diagnoses among U.S. children must mean more exposure to some outside influence: a drug, a chemical, a toxin, a vaccine.

“One of the things that I think that we need to move away from today is this ideology that ... the autism prevalence increase, the relentless increases, are simply artifacts of better diagnoses, better recognition or changing diagnostic criteria,” Kennedy said in April.

Kennedy is correct that autism spectrum disorder rates have risen steadily in the U.S. since the U.S. Centers for Disease Control be

[See Autism, A8]

Troubling spotlight on street violence

Podcasters, YouTubers offer news, rumors on L.A. gangs. Do they help or hurt the city?

By LIBOR JANY

A group of men were hanging around outside a liquor store in the strip mall on Manchester Avenue and Figueroa Street in South Los Angeles when they spotted a woman walk past.

As two of the men moved toward her, two others appeared in the parking lot. Surveillance video from the incident last month — since widely shared online — captured what happened next: A hail of bullets. People scrambling for cover. A body sprawled on the pavement.

The video was replayed over and over on YouTube after it was posted by an account called Hood War Stories. Operated anonymously, the account is one of several with large followings that are dedicated to chronicling gang culture across Los Angeles, offering a combustible mix of news and wild speculation.

While drawing fans by providing an insider's view of a shadowy world, the content fans flames of simmering beefs, increasing the potential for retaliation, critics say.

Hood War Stories identified the man gunned down in the strip mall shooting by the nickname “Chipmunk” and called the killing “a tipping point that set the streets on fire.” Four others

[See Viral, A14]



MICHAEL M. SANTIAGO Getty Images

AT THE U.N., President Trump spoke about his crackdown on immigrants, calling it a humanitarian effort.

Refusal to air Kimmel could pit station owners against Disney

Nexstar and Sinclair run the risk of losing all ABC programming

By MEG JAMES AND STEPHEN BATTAGLIO

Television station giants Nexstar Media Group and Sinclair Broadcast Group said they will not run “Jimmy Kimmel Live!” as the Walt Disney Co. brings the ABC comedian back to television, setting up a potentially bruising conflict between the Burbank entertainment giant and some of its affiliates.

Disney on Monday reversed its suspension of the late-night talk show after the host's comments about the shooting death of conservative activist Charlie Kirk set off a political firestorm.

But the dispute, which brought enormous pressure on Disney and put it at odds with the Trump administration, is far from resolved, and highlights the significant role of tele-

vision station owners in the media business.

Nexstar and Sinclair both said they plan to keep Kimmel off the air in cities around the country as Kimmel's show returned to production Tuesday. The decisions could test the network's relationship with its affiliated TV stations, which have long been the foundation of the broadcasting business.

“We made a decision last week to preempt ‘Jimmy Kimmel Live!’ following what ABC referred to as Mr. Kimmel's ‘ill-timed and insensitive’ comments at a critical time in our national discourse,” Nexstar said Tuesday in a statement.

“We stand by that decision pending assurance that all parties are

committed to fostering an environment of respectful, constructive dialogue in the markets we serve,” Nexstar said.

The Irving, Texas-based company operates 32 ABC affiliate stations, including in Salt Lake City, Nashville and Billings, Mont. Nexstar and Sinclair collectively cover nearly 25% of U.S. television homes. Losing those stations for Kimmel will diminish the ratings and reach of advertisers who buy time in the ABC television program.

Nexstar needs the approval of the Federal Communications Commission for its \$6.2-billion takeover of Tegna, another large television station group. Last week, FCC Chair-

[See Kimmel, A11]

FCC ASSAILED: State Atty. Gen. Bonta calls on agency to stop ‘campaign of censorship.’ BUSINESS, A9



GABRIELA ORÁA For The Times

ARTURO SUAREZ, a Venezuelan migrant deported by the U.S. this year, walks in Caracas, the capital.

Venezuelan gang a convenient villain

Trump invokes Tren de Aragua as a threat to the U.S. Experts debunk his claims.

By KATE LINTHICUM

MEXICO CITY — To help justify a sweeping deportation campaign, an extraordinary U.S. military buildup in the Caribbean and unprecedented strikes on boats allegedly trafficking drugs, President Trump has repeated a mantra: Tren de Aragua.

He insists that the street gang, which was founded about a decade ago in Venezuela, is attempting an “invasion” of the United States and threatens “the stability of the international order in the Western Hemisphere.” Speaking at the United Na-

tions General Assembly on Tuesday, Trump described the group as “an enemy of all humanity” and an arm of Venezuela's authoritarian government.

According to experts who study the gang and Trump's own intelligence officials, none of that is true.

While Tren de Aragua has been linked to cases of human trafficking, extortion and kidnapping and has expanded its footprint as Venezuela's diaspora has spread throughout the Americas, there is little evidence that it poses a threat to the U.S.

“Tren de Aragua does not have the capacity to invade any country, especially the most powerful nation on Earth,” said Ronna Rísquez, a Venezuelan journalist who wrote a book about the gang. The group's prowess, she

[See Gang, A4]

Police resist ICE job offers

Agency uses big bucks to lure officers, angering local officials already struggling to fill their departments

By SONJA SHARP, SANDRA McDONALD AND BRITTNY MEJIA

In the push to expand as quickly as possible, U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement is aggressively wooing recruits with experience slapping handcuffs on suspects: sheriff's deputies, state troopers and local cops.

The agency even shelled out for airtime during an NFL game with an ad explicitly targeting officers.

“In sanctuary cities, dangerous illegals walk free as police are forced to stand

down,” the August recruitment ad warned over a sunset panorama of the Los Angeles skyline. “Join ICE and help us catch the worst of the worst.”

To meet its hiring goal, the Trump administration is offering hefty signing bonuses, student loan forgiveness and six-figure salaries to would-be deportation officers.

ICE has also broadened its pool of potential applicants by dropping age requirements, eliminating Spanish-language proficiency requirements and cutting back on training for new hires with law enforce-

ment experience.

Along the way, the agency has walked a delicate line, seeking to maintain cordial relations with local department leaders while trying to poach their officers.

“We're not trying to pilage a bunch of officers from other agencies,” said Tim Oberle, an ICE spokesman. “If you see opportunities to move up, make more money to take care of your family, of course you're going to want it.”

But despite the generous new compensation packages, experts said ICE is still coming up short in some of

[See ICE, A8]

Trump snubs top Democrats

The president cancels healthcare negotiations as a potential federal government shutdown draws closer. NATION, A6

A timeless voice gets a tribute

Stevie Wonder and others will honor the late Minnie Riperton at the Hollywood Bowl. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 85/66. B6

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JEFF CHIU Associated Press

BACK IN THE BALLGAME

An Oakland Baller takes the field in July. After losing three major teams, the city finds redemption in its minor league upstart. CALIFORNIA, B1